

Unhappy consumers

Consumer Reports magazine, which recently polled subscribers to its Web site, said that the results show customer satisfaction with technical support is down across the PC industry. "Consumers are particularly concerned with increased time spent on hold as well as dropped calls to technical support," said Mark Kotkin, assistant director of survey research for *Consumer Reports*. The lone bright spot in the survey was Apple, which grabbed the top spot with a score of 74 out of 100 and was the only company to earn

higher marks this year than it did last year. Dell and Gateway were neck and neck with scores of 65 and 64, respectively. HP was fourth with a score of 56, while Compaq Computer received a score of 52.

Customer service has been an area of focus for HP and Compaq, HP spokesman David Albritton said. "We've definitely seen that we've needed to improve over time," he added, and claims that HP's own analysis of customer service data differs from the study. Albritton said the company



has already taken steps, including increased training for customer service workers as well as shifting schedules so more people are on the phones during peak calling times. Other vendors are of a similar opinion, but are quick to put the blame on new, untrained staff and high PC penetration.

Greece bans all computer games

The government of Greece has made a heroic effort to ban all electronic games. Something as innocent as playing *Pac Man* is now a crime with penalties of up to three months in jail and a fine of 10,000 Euros. The purpose is to crack down on Internet gambling, which already was illegal. Improved enforcement of the existing law is all that was needed, but unfortunate-

ly, the Greek government is "incapable of distinguishing innocuous video games from illegal gambling machines,"



according to an article in the English-language *Kathimerini* newspaper.

Earlier the Greek government had outlawed all LAN and Internet games and any kind of game that is supported by electrical, electronic or software means in Internet cafes. If anybody had something looking like a game on the screen, the cafe manager would be liable for arrest.

Audiogalaxy returns

Audiogalaxy (www.audiogalaxy.com), one of the largest sources for downloading hundreds of genres of MP3 music, which had shut down due to piracy claims, is back. It has launched a new subscription service called Rhapsody which gives you instant, unlimited, on-demand access to over 17,000 albums. The service will cost \$9.95 (approx Rs 500) per month, which pays royalties for the music. A Rhapsody subscription features a personal music library to organise music by artist, album, track, playlist or radio station, custom playlists that can be shared and many other features, in addition to Audiogalaxy's powerful music search and editorial recommendations.

snapshot

Internet penetration to cross **11.64 million** in Asia by 2003

Source: Gartner

A brand new Opera

Opera, the self-described fastest Web browser, is on the verge of releasing a beta version of Opera 7, which will resemble its predecessor only in looks. The rendering engine—the heart of the browser, which interprets and displays HTML pages—has been rewritten from ground up over the past 18 months.

Dubbed Project Presto, the rewritten browser is designed to make Opera both faster and more compatible with the Document Object Model

(DOM), an emerging standard technology that lets scripts such as JavaScript act on individual elements of a Web page.



"There were some things that were difficult to do with the old engine, particularly with

changing elements in pages," said Opera Software co-founder and CEO Jon S. von Tetzchner. "We felt we needed a rewritten engine to have something that works with all the DOM that is coming out."

Tetzchner resisted comparisons to Netscape's gamble in 1998 to cast off its legacy code in favour of a new browser that would be more in line with industry standards and more easily separable into components. "Our old engine wasn't that bad," Tetzchner

said. And indeed the Opera rewrite has proved to be far quicker and less painful than Netscape's, which dragged on for four years before producing marketable results. Opera Software employs about 60 engineers. When Project Presto began 18 months ago, two of them were working on it; now a majority have left the legacy Opera code behind.

In addition to the new rendering engine, Opera 7 will include rewritten mail and news clients.

